BEAUTIFUL GAME

Seeking to channel football's all-pervading popularity in Bengal towards extending political control, the Trinamool Congress is spreading its tentacles in the sport's administration

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar



DODGE AND DRIBBLE
Mamata Banerjee inaugurates the Durand Cup in Kolkata, Aug. 3

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

Bengal's all-consuming and undiluted love for football has an early milestone. In 1911, Mohun Bagan became the first Indian side to win the IFA Shield after defeating the East Yorkshire regiment. Footballing success thereafter generated fierce nationalistic pride, serving as a sporting adjunct of the freedom movement. In recent decades, the passion for football has come in useful for political purposes, too. *Khela Hobe* (the game's on) became Mamata's rallying cry in the 2021 assembly election, as broken foot and all, she led the Trinamool Congress to a magnificent win. She was certainly not the first to realise the demotic pull of the beautiful game, especially among the youth. Veteran leaders Jatin Chakraborty and Kshiti Goswami of the Revolutionary Socialist Party have had long associations with the three major football clubs of the Kolkata maidan—Mohun Bagan, East Bengal and Mohammedan Sporting. Under the Trinamool Congress, however, patronage of the game and exploitation of its mass appeal have reached another proportion.

MAMATA'S GOALPOSTS

As a means to tighten and maintain control over specific areas, football is now a part of the franchisee politics as practised by the TMC. Grassroots leaders are free to cash in on the party name and the charisma of party chief and West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee in exchange for total loyalty to her. While informal tournaments have always been a part of the state's football culture, the mushrooming numbers are a recent phenomenon. Almost all of them—either directly or by proxy—are patronised by Trinamool leaders. According to conservative estimates, close to 20,000 unregistered football tournaments are organised across Bengal.

Mamata herself is not only a force behind the semi-formal kickabouts across the state, she has also been a patron of top clubs. For instance, she helped find sponsors for East Bengal twice, enabling the team to play the Indian Super League, the highest-level football league in India. First, she played a major role in bringing Shree Cement Limited (SCL) on board as the team's sponsor in 2020. In 2022, after SCL terminated its contract, Mamata helped the club find its new investors, the Emami Group. Her meetings with the East Bengal officials and the businesses were televised. Clearly, it was imperative to project the CM as the messiah of the club in front of its numerous supporters.

The West Bengal chief minister has also lavished funds and attention on football since coming to power in 2011. The TMC government has spent a whopping Rs 18.59 crore since that time towards developing football infrastructure in the state. The funds have been allocated either by the sports or public works departments or from the Members of Parliament Local Area Development Scheme. The largest chunk—Rs 7.6 crore— has gone to the